However, as D.B. Venkatesh Varma, a former Indian ambassador to Russia, points out, "Given its close relations with Russia, and also its dependence on it for defence, oil and fertilisers, India took the right decision not to impact its bilateral relations as well as its core national interests. For its part, Russia has only a few friends and doesn't want to lose India." Asked whether India would push for a solution to the Russia-Ukraine war at the G20, Prime Minister Modi had in an exclusive interview, told the INDIA TODAY Group: "You should assess whether it is desirable to link G20 or our G20 presidency to this issue. There are problems in other parts of the world like Syria, in some countries in Africa, in East Asia, in Latin America. There are international organisations like the United Nations that are focusing on these issues. My focus is that we will steer the G20 presidency to build a common position on development that is of importance for the Global South."

CHAMPION OF THE GLOBAL SOUTH

Becoming the voice and the champion of the Global South may turn out to be India's single largest contribution to the New Delhi G20, for which the credit should go to Modi. Under his instructions, Indian negotiators handling key groupings worked towards making that visible in the consensus reached on most issues. India realised early enough the futility of getting into tricky geopolitical issues, particularly the Russian invasion of Ukraine. While initially there was talk of Modi using his good offices to end the Russian impasse, with the two sides so polarised, India decided to limit its arbitration role. Instead, it focused on pushing for greater representation of issues concerning the Global South that have come to represent most of the emerging as well as developing economies.

Amitabh Kant, India's sherpa for the G20, says, "Among the key achievements of this G20 is that India has been voice of the Global South. It has covered a lot of ground for bringing the developed, developing and emerging markets together. And it was Prime Minister Modi who pushed for making the African Union a permanent member." Elaborating on some of the measures that India has pushed through, Kant said, "With one-third of the world in recession, we pushed for globally sustainable growth. We also wanted to accelerate the pace of implementation of the UN's Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) because post-Covid, a lot of people went below the poverty line. That required not just green action, but also finances and a green bank to facilitate it. As climate action needs finance, it also called for reform of existing multilateral development financial institutions. To ensure financial inclusion, the digital public infrastructure India has worked on is now critical for the world, and that finds a prominent place. As critical is recognising and nurturing the role of women-led development."

On the financial track, the working groups were able to move the ball considerably forward on all key issues and come up with innovative solutions. Among the key areas of reform was in the realm of crypto assets. As finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman put it, "Crypto is as much a threat as an opportunity, and unless there is global cooperation, we will not be able to have a responsible financial ecosystem and regulate it well." The G20 working group came up with both policy formulations and a regulation roadmap to be monitored jointly by the IMF and the Financial Stability Board (FSB).

On the question of financial inclusion, citing the fact that as many as 1.4 billion people across the globe do not have a bank account and more than a billion are unable to prove their identity and so lack access to vital services such as healthcare, education and finance, India, using its Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) as an example, pushed for a Financial Inclusion Action Plan spanning the next three years (2024 to 2026). It could also serve as a roadmap for other developing countries. Economic Affairs Secretary Ajay Seth, who chaired the G20 meetings of finance deputies, says, "India's population-wide example of DPI gave it strong credentials to argue that such infrastructure would not only achieve financial inclusion but also enable the private sector, gaining efficiency and productivity." India is being made co-chair of the Global Partnership for Financial Inclusion (GPFI), the G20 body that formulates and oversees its implementation.


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